

tmx-session-passwords

tmx session passwords — user guide

Revision: 1 **Last modified:** 2026-07-05T00:00:00Z

What this is

Every tmx session can optionally be password-protected. The password is stored as a salted hash in `~/.tmx/state.json` (or `$TMX_STATE_FILE`), never in plaintext, and is checked by `scripts/tmx-state-bin` — a small Go binary that ships alongside the wrapper.

Creating a password-protected session

Run `tmx new -s NAME` (directly, or by typing `NAME` at the interactive wizard prompt — see `docs/guides/tmx-shell-integration.md`). If `NAME` has never been protected before, you are prompted:

```
[tmx] Enter session name "NAME" (blank = none):
```

Leave it blank for no password. Type anything else and you are asked to confirm it:

```
[tmx] Confirm password:
```

The two entries must match exactly (masked with `*` as you type, both times). If they don't match, you get:

```
[tmx] passwords did not match, try again
```

and are prompted again — up to 3 attempts. After the 3rd mismatch, the session is **not** created at all (no half-configured session is left behind) and `tmx` exits with an error.

Opening an already-protected session

Whether the session is currently running, or was torn down by the idle recycler after a period of inactivity (its password always survives that teardown), opening it — via `tmx attach -t NAME`, `tmx new -s NAME`, or picking it from the wizard's existing-session menu — always shows exactly **one** prompt:

```
[tmx] Session "NAME" is password-protected. Enter password:
```

The correct password attaches you immediately; nothing else is asked. A wrong password is rejected and the session is left completely alone.

Resetting a session's password

`tmx delete -t NAME` tears the session down **and** clears all of its persisted state, including its password. The next `tmx new -s NAME` (or re-typing that exact name if you used `TMX_EXACT_NAME=1`) is treated as genuinely fresh — you'll get the create-and-confirm flow again.

Why you might have seen "asked twice" before 2026-07-05

Prior to this date, reopening a session that had been idle-recycled could show a confusing **SECOND** prompt that looked like it might reset your password. That was a bug (root-caused and fixed the same day — see [docs/superpowers/specs/2026-07-05-tmx-wizard-password-redesign-design.md](#) for the full forensic write-up); it no longer happens.

Decision flow

The diagram below traces the full decision path both entry points take — `tmx new -s NAME` and `tmx attach -t NAME` — from the has-password probe through **verify-once** (existing password) or **set-and-confirm** (brand-new name). The diagram source is [docs/guides/tmx-session-passwords-decision-flow.mmd](#); the rendered image is [docs/guides/tmx-session-passwords-decision-flow.png](#).

